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Still the people's princess

Story by Tina Brown

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This month, Diana would have turned 50. What would she have been like? Still great-looking? That's a given. Fashion-wise, Diana would have gone the Galliano route, always knowing how to mix the casual with the glam. Remarriage? At least two, she would have seen grown exasperated with Dodi. Al Fayed's hopeless-minded child. Politically, Diana would have been at home with David Cameron and all the old Etonians who now run Britain. She would, much earlier, have parted company with Tony Blair, stung by his failure to rise to her for big preening missions overseas. And Kate? How would Diana have handled her son's affection for her? Diana would have had to adjust to a broadening of the spotlight. Her edge over Kate, of course, was her own aptitude of princessly suffering. Diana, rejecting in her fearless Spenser pedigree, would have been a firm defender of the Middletons against the palace snobs and ostentatiously made "Carle Middleton her new BFF." Would our heroine be more like "found peace?"

Yes, I believe she would have, sustained by the two things she cared about most: her children and her humanitarian passion. Had she lived, her Princess Diana Foundation, would have become largely prestigious, and powerful. In the world disasters of the last few years, Diana would have been first at the scene in a hard hat with a camera crew, and, by now, 10 million followers on Twitter. "Diana's never slumbering," 14-year-old William told his mother when she'd been stripped of her HRH at the time of the divorce. "I will give it back to you when I am king." In many ways, he already has. He made such efforts to include the memory of his mother on the most important day of his life. The engagement ring he placed on Kate's finger belonged to Diana. The spring heath at the wedding was one of Diana's favorites. More than any gesture of significance, William took Kate on a sacred trip to visit Diana's grave. Waiting years to do it, he showed that Diana still lives and is vibrant in his memory. And in ours.



If not for that tragic night, what might Diana's life have looked like now? Though that remains a mystery, her legacy lives on through her son and the causes she supported, such as the Comic Relief charity for homeless youth and the Legacy Mission.



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